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2027 CYCLE

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CUET UG

Political Science

Alternative Centers of Power

Official Syllabus · Contemporary World Politics · Class 12 · CUET UG 2027 Cycle Notes

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Syllabus Alignment

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA CUET(UG) Political Science syllabus 2026, the current 2027 baseline — Contemporary World Politics)	Skills the questions test
The European Union (EU)	Creation and expansion of the European Union; political, economic, and military influence.	Tracing milestones: 1948 Marshall Plan, 1957 Treaty of Rome, 1992 Maastricht Treaty, 2002 Euro currency, and structural limitations (failed 2005 constitution, Brexit).
ASEAN & The 'ASEAN Way'	Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN); the ASEAN Way; Three Pillars of the ASEAN Community.	Identifying the 1967 Bangkok Declaration, 5 founding nations, the ASEAN Security, Economic, and Socio-Cultural communities (2003), and ARF (1994).
Rise of China (Post-Mao Era)	Rise of China as an economic power in the post-Mao era; economic reforms and WTO entry.	Analyzing Zhou Enlai's Four Modernisations (1973), Deng Xiaoping's Open Door Policy (1978), phased privatization (agriculture 1982, industry 1998), and 2001 WTO entry.
India-China Relations	India's changing relations with China: cooperation, trade expansion, and border disputes.	Detailing the 1954 Panchsheel Agreement, 1962 border war, 1988 Rajiv Gandhi visit, 1993 border peace accord, Doklam (2017), Galwan (2020), and CPEC disputes.
India-Japan & South Korea	India's changing relations with Japan and South Korea: strategic, economic, and technological ties.	Evaluating the Mumbai-Ahmedabad bullet train (Shinkansen),

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Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA CUET(UG) Political Science syllabus 2026, the current 2027 baseline — Contemporary World Politics)	Skills the questions test
		Tokyo Declaration (2014), Quad partnership, and South Korea's CEPA (2010).
BRICS & Alternative Finance	Emergence of alternative multilateral economic institutions.	Recalling BRICS formation (2006/2010), the New Development Bank (NDB) in Shanghai, and multipolar global governance.

CUET UG Exam Strategy — Chapter 2 Focus (World Politics)

- **Pattern:** 50 Multiple Choice Questions (attempt any 40) in 60 minutes.
- **Marking:** +5 marks for correct choice, −1 mark negative deduction for incorrect choice.
- **High-Yield Angles:** Founding members of ASEAN (1967) vs later entrants, exact dates of EU treaties (Rome 1957, Maastricht 1992), China's phased economic reforms (1978, 1982, 1998, 2001), and bilateral treaties with Japan and South Korea.

1. The European Union (EU)

The European Union represents the world's most successful experiment in regional economic and political integration, evolving from the ashes of post-World War II devastation.

Historical Evolution of Integration

- **The Marshall Plan (1948):** The United States extended massive financial aid under the European Recovery Program (**Marshall Plan**) to reconstruct Western European economies and contain Soviet communist expansion.
- **Organisation for European Economic Cooperation (OEEC, 1948):** Established to channel Marshall Plan aid and foster multilateral European trade.
- **Council of Europe (1949):** Formed as a political consultative body to promote human rights, democracy, and rule of law.
- **Treaty of Rome (1957):** Six founding nations (**France, West Germany, Italy, Belgium, Netherlands, Luxembourg**) signed the Treaty of Rome, establishing the **European Economic Community (EEC)** and the European Atomic Energy Community (Euratom).
- **Single European Act (1986):** Paved the way for the creation of a seamless single European market with free movement of goods, capital, services, and people.

- **Maastricht Treaty (February 1992):** Signed in the Netherlands, this landmark treaty formally established the **European Union (EU)**, inaugurating common foreign and security policies, judicial cooperation, and laying the groundwork for a single currency.
- **The Euro Currency (January 2002):** The physical Euro currency notes and coins entered public circulation across participating Eurozone nations.

Dimensions of EU Influence

- **Economic Power:** The EU operates as the world's second-largest economy, with an aggregate GDP exceeding $17 trillion. Its shared currency, the **Euro**, acts as an international reserve currency capable of challenging the dominance of the US dollar.
- **Diplomatic & Political Weight:** One EU member state (**France**) holds a permanent, veto-wielding seat on the United Nations Security Council, alongside multiple non-permanent members.
- **Military Might:** The combined armed forces of the EU rank second only to the United States in global military expenditure.

Limitations of European Integration

- **Absence of a Unified Foreign Policy:** Member states frequently disagree on foreign military interventions (e.g., Britain and Spain supported the US invasion of Iraq in 2003, while France and Germany vehemently opposed it).
- **Failed Constitutional Treaty (2005):** A draft Constitution for Europe was rejected by popular referendums in France and the Netherlands, halting deeper political unification.
- **Euroscepticism and Brexit:** Deep popular resentment against Brussels regulations led the United Kingdom to vote to leave the EU in a 2016 referendum, culminating in formal **Brexit on 31 January 2020**.
- **Monetary Opt-Outs:** Nations like **Denmark and Sweden** resisted the Maastricht provisions, retaining their national currencies (Krone and Krona).

2. Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN)

Southeast Asia suffered centuries of Western colonial exploitation, followed by intense Cold War ideological conflicts (the Vietnam War) and territorial disputes. To overcome regional vulnerabilities, Southeast Asian leaders constructed ASEAN.

Founding and Membership Expansion

- **The Bangkok Declaration (8 August 1967):** ASEAN was established with the signing of the Bangkok Declaration by five founding nations:
  1. **Indonesia**
  2. **Malaysia**
  3. **The Philippines**
  4. **Singapore**
  5. **Thailand**
- **Membership Expansion:** Expanded to ten members by inducting **Brunei Darussalam** (1984), **Vietnam** (1995), **Laos** (1997), **Myanmar** (1997), and **Cambodia** (1999).

The Distinctive 'ASEAN Way'

- The **"ASEAN Way"** refers to a unique diplomatic culture based on:
  - **Informality & Consensus:** Avoidance of legalistic supranational institutions in favor of informal, quiet consultations.
  - **Non-Confrontation:** Commitment to resolving regional friction without public disputes or armed conflict.
  - **Strict Non-Interference:** Absolute respect for member states' sovereign domestic affairs and territorial integrity.

The Three Pillars of the ASEAN Community (2003)

At the 2003 Bali Summit, ASEAN leaders resolved to establish an ASEAN Community built on three interconnected pillars:

- **1. ASEAN Security Community (ASC):**
  - Dedicated to ensuring that territorial disputes do not escalate into armed confrontations.
  - Governed by the **Treaty of Amity and Cooperation (TAC)** in Southeast Asia.
  - Supported by the **ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF)**, established in **1994** to conduct multilateral security and defense dialogue among 27 partner nations (including India, the US, China, and Russia).
- **2. ASEAN Economic Community (AEC):**
  - Creates a single market and unified manufacturing production base across Southeast Asia.
  - Facilitates the free flow of goods, services, foreign investment, and skilled technical professionals.
  - Negotiated comprehensive Free Trade Agreements (FTAs) with India, China, Japan, and Australia.
- **3. ASEAN Socio-Cultural Community (ASCC):**
  - Promotes regional cooperation in education, disaster relief, environmental sustainability, and cultural preservation.

3. The Rise of China as an Economic Superpower

Following the founding of the People's Republic of China (PRC) in 1949 under **Mao Zedong**, China operated a closed, autarkic Soviet-style command economy. Although it established heavy state industries and provided basic education and healthcare, per capita economic growth remained sluggish (2–3% annually).

The Shift to Market Socialism (Post-Mao Reforms)

China avoided Soviet-style Shock Therapy, adopting instead a disciplined, phased transition toward a market economy:

- **The Four Modernisations (1973):** Premier **Zhou Enlai** proposed modernizing four critical sectors: **Agriculture, Industry, National Defense, and Science & Technology**.
- **Deng Xiaoping's "Open Door Policy" (December 1978):**

- **Deng Xiaoping** announced the historic "Open Door Policy", ending China's self-imposed economic isolation.
- Pragmatic ideology: "It does not matter whether a cat is black or white, as long as it catches mice."
- Welcomed foreign direct investment and high technology from Western capitalist economies.

- **Phased Step-by-Step Privatisation:**
  - **Privatisation of Agriculture (1982):** Abolished the commune system, leasing state land to peasant households (**Household Responsibility System**). Agricultural productivity and rural private savings surged dramatically.
  - **Privatisation of Industry (1998):** Phased privatization of state-owned commercial and industrial enterprises.
  - **Special Economic Zones (SEZs):** Created tariff-free coastal industrial enclaves (Shenzhen, Zhuhai, Xiamen) offering tax holidays to foreign multinational corporations.
- **Accession to the WTO (December 2001):** China formally joined the World Trade Organization, integrating its manufacturing supply chains with the global capitalist economy.

Projected Global Dominance

- China has maintained an average annual GDP growth rate of 8–10% over four decades, lifting over 800 million citizens out of extreme poverty.
- Projections by global financial institutions estimate that China's economy will surpass that of the United States as the world's largest economy by approximately **2040**.

4. India-China Relations: Cooperation and Conflict

Relations between India and China—the world's two ancient Asian civilizations and demographic giants—have oscillated between romanticized brotherhood and intense military rivalry.

Early Optimism and the 1962 Border War

- **Panchsheel Agreement (29 April 1954):** Signed by Prime Ministers Jawaharlal Nehru and Zhou Enlai, articulating the **Five Principles of Peaceful Coexistence**. The agreement formally recognized Chinese sovereignty over Tibet.
- **Deterioration of Ties (Late 1950s):**
  - China's brutal military suppression of the Tibetan uprising and India's decision to grant political asylum to the **14th Dalai Lama** in 1959 outraged Beijing.
  - Boundary disputes surfaced over the **McMahon Line** in Arunachal Pradesh (Eastern Sector) and **Aksai Chin** in Ladakh (Western Sector).
- **The 1962 Sino-Indian War:** China launched simultaneous surprise military offensives in October 1962, overrunning Indian defense positions in Ladakh and Arunachal Pradesh (NEFA) before declaring a unilateral ceasefire. Diplomatic relations were reduced to charge d'affaires level until 1976.

Normalisation and Economic Interdependence

- **Rajiv Gandhi's Historic Visit (December 1988):** Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi made a breakthrough visit to Beijing—the first by an Indian Prime Minister in 34 years. Both nations agreed to normalize trade and cultural ties while establishing a Joint Working Group to negotiate the boundary dispute.
- **1993 Border Peace & Tranquility Agreement:** Signed during P.V. Narasimha Rao's visit, committing both nations to maintain peace along the **Line of Actual Control (LAC)**.
- **Explosion of Bilateral Trade:** Bilateral merchandise trade crossed **$100 billion**, making China one of India's largest trading partners (though marked by a massive trade deficit favoring China).

Continuing Strategic Friction

- **Border Clashes:** The 73-day military standoff at the **Doklam plateau** (2017) and the deadly hand-to-hand combat in the **Galwan Valley** (June 2020) resulted in military casualties and militarization along the LAC.
- **China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC):** India vehemently protests CPEC, a flagship project of China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI), because it passes through Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK), violating Indian sovereignty.
- **String of Pearls & Maritime Rivalry:** Chinese naval expansion across the Indian Ocean (ports in Gwadar, Hambantota, Chittagong, Kyaukpyu) challenges India's traditional maritime security perimeter.

5. India's Relations with Japan and South Korea

As part of its "Look East" (1991) and "Act East" (2014) foreign policies, New Delhi has forged deep economic, industrial, and strategic partnerships with East Asia's democratic powerhouses.

India-Japan Partnership

- **Special Strategic and Global Partnership:** Bilateral ties were upgraded during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's 2014 visit to Tokyo with Prime Minister Shinzo Abe.
- **Infrastructure & Technology:**
  - Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA) has financed critical Indian mega-infrastructure, including the Delhi Metro and the Western Dedicated Freight Corridor.
  - **Mumbai-Ahmedabad High Speed Rail:** Japan is financing and providing **Shinkansen (Bullet Train)** technology for India's first high-speed rail corridor.
- **Security & Quad:** Both nations participate in the **Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (Quad)** alongside the US and Australia, and conduct the annual high-intensity **Malabar naval exercises**.
- **2+2 Dialogue:** Regular institutional dialogue involving the Defense and Foreign Ministers of both countries.

India-South Korea Partnership

- **Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA, 2010):** Bilateral trade and market access agreement that spurred bilateral commerce.
- **Industrial Powerhouse Presence:** South Korean conglomerates (**Chaebols**)—including **Samsung, Hyundai, and LG**—have made colossal investments in India, setting up the world's largest mobile phone manufacturing factory in Noida (Uttar Pradesh).
- **Special Strategic Partnership (2015):** Upgraded during Prime Minister Modi's visit to Seoul, focusing on defense production (K9 Vajra self-propelled howitzers licensed to L&T), shipbuilding, and clean technology.

6. BRICS and Alternative Financial Architectures

- **Formation:** The acronym **BRIC** was coined in 2001 by Goldman Sachs economist Jim O'Neill to describe the four fastest-growing emerging economies: **Brazil, Russia, India, and China**.
- **Formalization:** First summit held in Yekaterinburg (Russia) in 2009. **South Africa** was officially inducted in **2010**, transforming the bloc into **BRICS**.
- **New Development Bank (NDB):** Established at the 6th BRICS Summit in Fortaleza (Brazil) in 2014, with headquarters in **Shanghai**, to fund infrastructure and sustainable development projects in emerging economies as an alternative to the World Bank and IMF.
- **Contingent Reserve Arrangement (CRA):** A $100-billion reserve framework to protect member states against global balance of payments shocks.
- **Expansion (2024):** Expanded membership to include Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, and the United Arab Emirates (UAE), consolidating the Global South's voice for a multipolar financial order.

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The Whole Chapter in One Picture

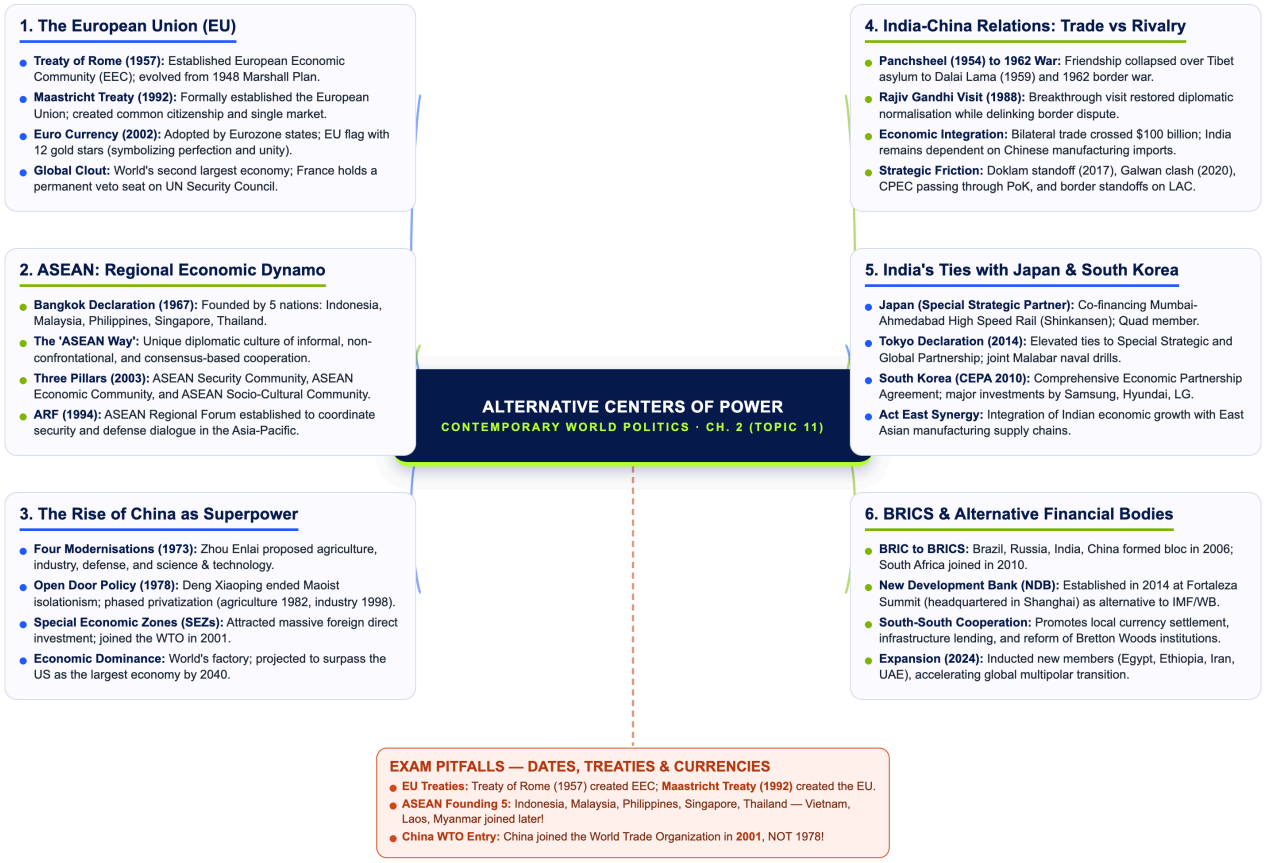


Figure 1: Alternative Centers of Power Mindmap: The European Union, ASEAN Way and Three Pillars, China's post-Mao reforms, India-China relations, and Japan-South Korea ties.

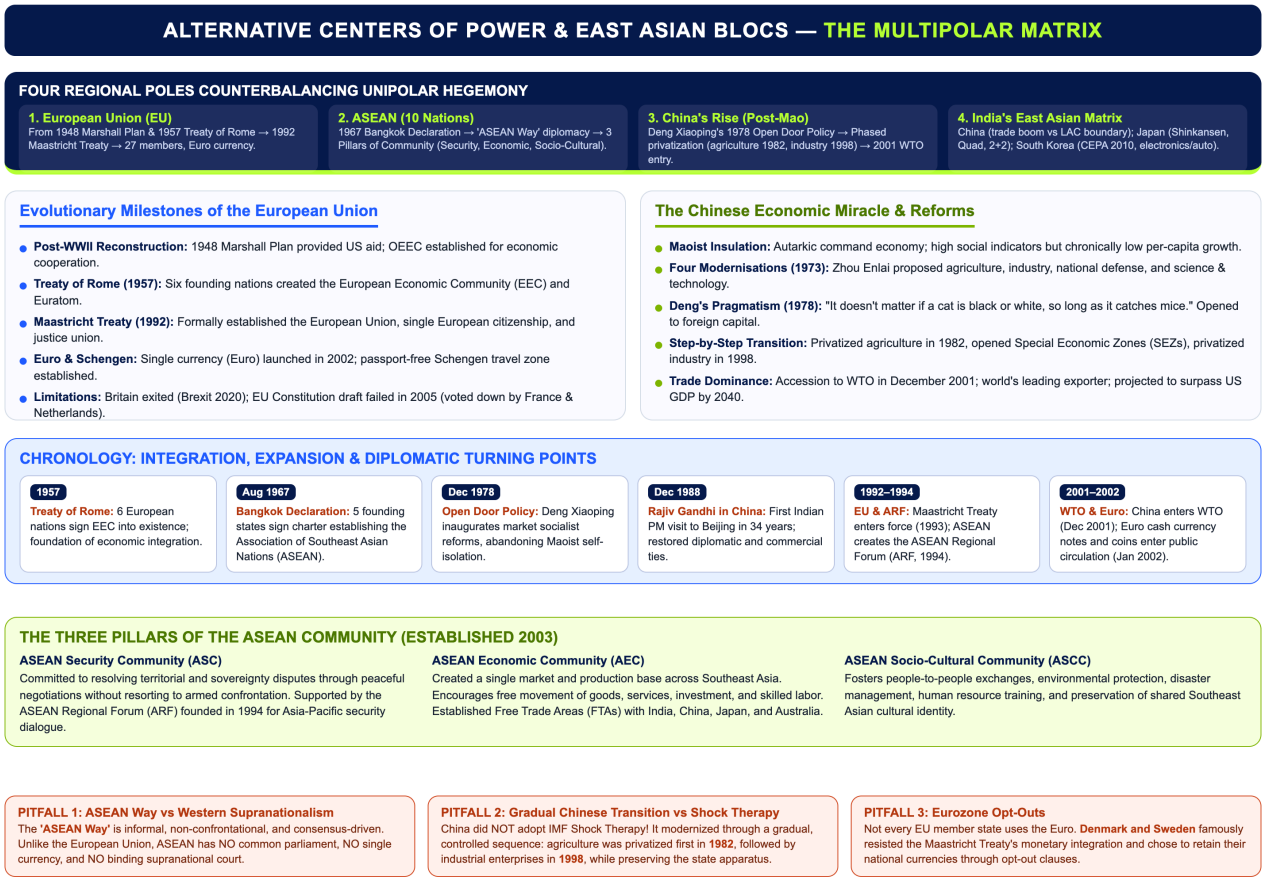


Figure 2: Multipolar Power Matrix: Timeline of integration (1957–2002), Chinese reform chronology, ASEAN community pillars, and key exam pitfalls.

Practice Questions (Exam Pattern)

Ten questions designed in authentic CUET UG single-correct style. The official marking scheme awards +5 for each correct answer and deducts −1 for every incorrect answer.

Q1. The European Economic Community (EEC) and Euratom were formally established in 1957 by which landmark international treaty?

(A) Treaty of Versailles
(B) Treaty of Rome
(C) Maastricht Treaty
(D) Treaty of Lisbon

Q2. In which year did the physical Euro currency notes and coins enter public circulation across participating European Union member states?

(A) 1992
(B) 1999
(C) 2002
(D) 2005

Q3. Which two European Union member states famously secured opt-out clauses and resisted the adoption of the single European currency (Euro)?

(A) France and Germany
(B) Denmark and Sweden
(C) Italy and Spain
(D) Poland and Hungary

Q4. The Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) was founded in August 1967 with the signing of which declaration by five nations?

(A) Jakarta Declaration
(B) Manila Declaration
(C) Bangkok Declaration
(D) Bandung Declaration

Q5. Which of the following countries was NOT among the original five founding members of ASEAN in 1967?

(A) Indonesia
(B) Thailand
(C) Vietnam
(D) Philippines

Q6. The distinctive diplomatic culture of ASEAN characterized by informal, consensual, and non-confrontational dialogue is popularly referred to as the:

(A) Asian Century
(B) ASEAN Way
(C) Panchsheel Framework
(D) Look East Doctrine

Q7. Who announced the historic 'Four Modernisations' (agriculture, industry, defense, and science & technology) in China in 1973?

(A) Mao Zedong
(B) Zhou Enlai
(C) Deng Xiaoping
(D) Xi Jinping

Q8. In which year did Deng Xiaoping launch the revolutionary 'Open Door Policy' and economic modernization reforms in China?

(A) 1971
(B) 1976
(C) 1978
(D) 1982

Q9. In which year did the People's Republic of China formally gain accession to the World Trade Organization (WTO)?

(A) 1978
(B) 1991
(C) 1998
(D) 2001

Q10. Which Indian Prime Minister made a historic visit to China in December 1988, ending 34 years of diplomatic freeze since the 1962 border war?

(A) Indira Gandhi
(B) Rajiv Gandhi
(C) P.V. Narasimha Rao
(D) Atal Bihari Vajpayee

Detailed Solutions

Sol. Q1. The Treaty of Rome was signed in March 1957 by France, West Germany, Italy, Belgium, the Netherlands, and Luxembourg, creating the European Economic Community (EEC).

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q2. While the Euro was introduced electronically in 1999 for banking transactions, physical Euro currency notes and coins entered daily public circulation on 1 January 2002.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q3. Denmark and Sweden exercised opt-out provisions from the Maastricht Treaty monetary guidelines, refusing to adopt the Euro and preserving their national currencies.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q4. ASEAN was founded on 8 August 1967 with the signing of the Bangkok Declaration by the foreign ministers of Indonesia, Malaysia, Philippines, Singapore, and Thailand.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q5. Vietnam was not a founding member in 1967; it was admitted into ASEAN decades later in 1995 following the resolution of the Cambodian conflict.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q6. The 'ASEAN Way' is the recognized term for Southeast Asian diplomacy based on quiet informality, non-confrontation, mutual respect for sovereignty, and consensus building.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q7. Chinese Premier Zhou Enlai introduced the Four Modernisations in 1973 to upgrade agriculture, industry, national defense, and science & technology.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q8. Deng Xiaoping declared the 'Open Door Policy' in December 1978 at the Third Plenum of the 11th Central Committee of the CCP, inaugurating market-oriented reforms.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q9. China was officially admitted into the World Trade Organization in December 2001, anchoring its position as the premier manufacturing exporter to the world.

Answer: (D)

Sol. Q10. Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi traveled to Beijing in December 1988, holding landmark talks with Deng Xiaoping that normalized diplomatic, trade, and cultural relations.

Answer: (B)

Wrong-Answer Clinic — the one-line corrections

If you answered...	Your slip was...	The corrected rule, in one line
Q1 option C	Confusing 1957 and 1992 treaties	Treaty of Rome (1957) created the EEC; Maastricht Treaty (1992) established the EU.
Q4 option D	Confusing ASEAN with NAM	The Bandung Conference (1955) led to NAM; the Bangkok Declaration (1967) founded ASEAN.
Q5 option C	Assuming Vietnam was an original member	Vietnam joined in 1995; the original 5 were Indonesia, Malaysia, Philippines, Singapore, Thailand.
Q7 option C	Attributing the Four Modernisations to Deng	Zhou Enlai proposed the 4 Modernisations (1973); Deng Xiaoping implemented the Open Door policy (1978).
Q9 option A	Confusing Open Door year with WTO accession	Open Door was launched in 1978; China joined the WTO in 2001.

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